The Investment Banking Resume

A banking resume is not a career history. It is a one-page argument that you can do the work, read in under fifteen seconds by an analyst holding four hundred others. It fits on one page, it is built from quantified bullets, and it never uses a word you cannot defend in the interview. Everything below serves those three rules.

> **THE RULES OF THE ONE-PAGER**
>
> One page, no exceptions, ever. Reverse chronological. Standard banking template, not a Canva design. No photo, no color, no graphics, no skill bars. GPA on the page if it is 3.5 or higher. Every bullet starts with a verb and ends with a number. Saved and sent as one PDF named Firstname_Lastname_Resume.pdf. If a recruiter has to hunt for anything, you have already lost.

The Four Sections, In Order

Section	What goes in it
Education	School, degree, expected graduation, GPA (if 3.5+), and test scores if strong (SAT 1400+ / ACT 32+). Add relevant coursework, honors, and any modeling or valuation certification. This is your top section until you have a banking internship to outrank it.
Professional Experience	Reverse chronological. Firm, title, location, dates. Three to five bullets per role, weighted toward the most recent and most relevant. Finance-adjacent roles beat prestigious unrelated ones. This is the section that gets read first and cut last.
Leadership & Involvement	Finance and investment clubs, case competitions, a fund you help run, a role where you led people or moved a number. Titles matter less than outcomes. One or two entries, bulleted the same way as experience.
Skills & Interests	One or two lines. Technical skills (Excel, financial modeling, Bloomberg, Python, PowerPoint), languages, and three or four specific interests. Specific interests are interview fuel; generic ones are wasted space.

The Bullet Formula

Every bullet answers three questions in one line: what did you do, how did you do it, and what happened. Action verb, then method, then a quantified result.

> **DO THIS**
>
> `Built a three-statement DCF model in Excel to value a $40M acquisition target, informing a bid the deal team raised by 8%.`
>
> Verb first ("Built"). Method named ("three-statement DCF"). Result quantified and tied to a decision ("raised by 8%"). You can defend every clause in an interview.

> **NOT THIS**
>
> `Responsible for assisting with various financial analysis and modeling tasks for the team as needed.`
>
> No verb, no method, no number, no defensible claim. This bullet could belong to anyone in any role and proves nothing. It is the first line a screener cuts.

Read every bullet out loud. If it has no number in it, you have described a duty, not a result. Duties are invisible on a banking resume.

The Mistakes and the Final Pass

Most resumes are not rejected for what they lack. They are rejected for six errors a screener spots in seconds. Fix these before you send, then run the final pass below.

Six Ways a Resume Gets Cut

The mistake	Why it ends the read
Two pages	Signals you cannot prioritize. An analyst with no time reads the length as a lack of judgment before reading a word of content.
No numbers	Bullets that describe duties rather than results are unverifiable and forgettable. If nothing is measured, nothing is proven.
A claim you cannot defend	"Expert in LBO modeling" invites the question that ends the interview. Never put a word on the page you cannot walk through live.
Design over substance	Columns, color, headshots, and skill bars read as "does not know the industry." The plain template is the industry signal.
Typos and inconsistency	Mixed tenses, uneven dates, a period on some bullets and not others. In a job about precision, one slip suggests many.
Wrong or generic file	A file named "Resume_final_v3.docx" or a Word doc that reflows on their machine. Send a PDF, named with your full name.

The Final Pass Before You Send

- **One page, one PDF.** Print it. If it spills to a second page, cut, do not shrink the font below 10pt.
- **Every bullet starts with a verb, ends with a number.** Past tense for finished roles, present for current ones, consistent throughout.
- **Consistent formatting.** One serif font, one date format, aligned margins, identical bullet punctuation on every line.
- **Defensible top to bottom.** For every skill and deal listed, you can answer a follow-up question without hesitating.
- **Specific interests.** "Distance running (three marathons)" starts a conversation; "reading and music" does not.
- **A second set of eyes.** Someone in banking reads it before a recruiter does. They catch in ten seconds what you stopped seeing days ago.

Reviewed once, then sent. The failure mode is not a weak bullet. It is a strong resume held back for a month of polishing while the application window quietly closes.

Fifteen seconds. One page. Every line defensible.

Take the 60-second quiz and get your resume benchmarked against the desks you are targeting.

TAKE THE QUIZ → wallstalpha.com/apply

Educational only; not affiliated with or endorsed by any firm named. Guidance reflects prevailing recruiting norms as of July 2026 and can change without notice. Always verify current openings and eligibility on the official career page before applying.